Raka Datta

CONTACT

Department of Economics
Georgia State University
Atlanta, GA

Phone: +1-(470) 652-2702
Website: rakadatta.github.io
Email: dattarakaecon@gmail.com

FIELDS

Primary Field: Health Economics
Secondary Fields: Labor Economics, Applied Econometrics

EDUCATION

Georgia State University, Atlanta, GA — 2022–2027 (expected)
Ph.D. in Economics
Dissertation: "Essays on Health Economics"
Committee: Lauren Hoehn-Velasco (Chair), James Marton, Elaine Liu, Laura M. Argys

University of Bonn, Germany — 2019–2022
M.Sc. in Economics

Jawaharlal Nehru University, India — 2016–2018
M.A. in Economics

Jadavpur University, India — 2013–2016
B.Sc. in Economics (Honors)

PUBLICATIONS

Neonatal Mortality Risk Among Births in Freestanding Birth Centers, 2015–2024
with Lauren Hoehn-Velasco & Diana R. Jolles
Journal of Midwifery & Women's Health, 2026. doi.org/10.1111/jmwh.70177

Neonatal Mortality Risk in Planned Home Birth, 2015–2024
with Lauren Hoehn-Velasco & Diana R. Jolles
Journal of Midwifery & Women's Health, 2026. doi.org/10.1111/jmwh.70195

WORKING PAPERS

Dissertation Chapters

1. "Alcohol Access Shocks and Mortality" (Job Market Paper)

A substantial literature links the density of alcohol retail outlets to adverse health and social outcomes, but this evidence is often correlational and confined to a single city or region. In this paper, I provide causal evidence on whether physical alcohol retail access affects mortality. I develop a mortality-risk extension of the rational addiction model with access costs, and test its predictions against reduced-form estimates. I identify the effect from county-level, over-time variation in County Business Patterns liquor store establishment counts, matched to restricted-access NCHS Multiple Cause of Death mortality microdata, across U.S. counties from 1989 to 2016, and estimate two-way fixed effects and event-study specifications. Each additional liquor store per 100,000 residents raises alcohol-primary mortality by 0.048 deaths per 100,000 annually, a 0.65% increase relative to the pre-treatment mean. The effect is three times larger for off-premise retailers (e.g., liquor stores) than for on-premise establishments (e.g., bars), and concentrated among older adults, consistent with a chronic rather than acute consumption channel. Using a standard value of a statistical life, the estimated effect amounts to approximately $556,000 in annual mortality damages per additional store per 100,000 residents.

2. "Professional Recommendations and Provider Behavior"
with Lauren Hoehn-Velasco, Elizabeth Humphreys, & Nancy A. Niemczyk

Provider responses to updated clinical guidelines play a central role in shaping health outcomes. In this study, we examine how physicians respond to new randomized controlled trial (RCT) evidence. We analyze physician behavioral changes following the publication of the ARRIVE trial in obstetrics, which found that elective induction at 39 weeks can reduce cesarean delivery in low-risk, first-time pregnancies. Using nationally representative U.S. birth certificate data from 2016 to 2021, we document a rapid and sustained increase in 39-week inductions for low-risk first births by approximately 9%. Following the trial's release, inductions not only increase among first births but also among subsequent births, suggesting "off-label" application of the trial findings. Despite this significant shift in clinical practice, we find no corresponding decline in cesarean sections for first births. These findings highlight a significant discrepancy between trial-based findings and real-world application: while providers respond to high-quality clinical evidence, the anticipated downstream benefits may not surface. Our results highlight the importance of evaluating how evidence translates into practice and challenge the assumption that RCT findings necessarily imply population-level improvements.

3. "The Long-term Impact of In-Utero Alcohol Taxes on Adult Prenatal Drinking"
with Godwin Aipoh

Prior research documents the effects of alcohol taxes on drinking and birth outcomes, but their long-term intergenerational effects remain largely unexplored. We investigate whether in-utero exposure to state alcohol taxes shapes adult prenatal drinking decades later. Using U.S. birth certificate data (1989–2004) on 11.7 million first births, we link each mother's state and year of birth to the alcohol tax her mother faced during pregnancy, and estimate models with state and year fixed effects and cohort trends; event studies show no pre-trends. A one-dollar increase in the real in-utero alcohol tax per gallon of ethanol lowers the probability of prenatal drinking by 0.07 percentage points (about 7 percent of the mean). The effect operates entirely on the extensive margin, is concentrated among older, more-educated mothers, and comes with suggestive improvements in infant health, highlighting the durability of early-life policy interventions.

Work in Progress

"Advertising and Consumer Behavior in the Post-Dobbs Era" with Sukriti Beniwal & Nikita Dhingra
"State-Paid Leave and Healthcare Utilization for Infants" with Godwin Aipoh
"Heat Waves, Fertility, and Labor Market Outcomes in the U.S."
"Does Time Bridge Gaps? Long-Term Dynamics of the Child Penalty in Women's Earnings"

Research Experience

Graduate Research Assistant, Department of Economics, Georgia State University — 2022–present
Research Assistant, IZA – Institute of Labor Economics, Bonn, Germany — 2020–2022
Gender, Growth and Labor Markets in Low Income Countries Program

Teaching Experience

Primary Instructor
ECON 2106: Principles of Microeconomics — Spring 2025, Fall 2025

Teaching Assistant
ECON 8030: Mathematical Methods for Economists (PhD) — Fall 2023, 2024, 2025
ECON 4230: Experimental Economics — Spring 2025, 2026
ECON 3910: Microeconomics — 2024, 2025

Teaching Certification
GSU Center for Excellence in Teaching, Learning and Online Education (CETLOE) — Spring 2024

Grants & Awards

External
APPAM Excellence, Equity and Inclusion Student Fellowship (2026)
American Institutes for Research Fellowship Fund (2026)

Georgia State University
GTA Pedagogy Award (nominated by Department of Economics)
Professional Development Fund Award, AYS Career Services
E.D. (Jack) Dunn Fellowship and Research Fund (×2)
Bernard B. and Eugenia A. Ramsey Chair Funding (×2)
W.J. Usery Chair of the American Workplace Funding
Andrew Young Fellowship (3 years)

University of Bonn & JNU
University of Bonn: STIBET–I Fellowship
JNU: Indira Gandhi Fellowship

Presentations

2026: Population Association of America Annual Meeting; Eastern Economic Association Annual Meeting; ASHEcon Annual Conference; American Institutes for Research Conference; Southern Economic Association; APPAM Fall Research Conference

2025: Southern Economic Association; APPAM Fall Research Conference; ASHEcon Annual Meeting

Skills

Software: Stata, R, Python, LaTeX, oTree/zTree, MS Office
Key Datasets: NVSS, HCUP, Nielsen Retail Scanner & Ad Intel, County Business Patterns, NHTSA, BRFSS, PSID

References

Prof. Lauren Hoehn-Velasco (Chair)
Assistant Professor
Department of Economics
Georgia State University
lvelasco@gsu.edu

Prof. James Marton
Chair and Professor
Department of Economics
Georgia State University
marton@gsu.edu

Prof. Laura M. Argys
Executive Director, Rocky Mountain Research Data Center
School of Public Health
University of Colorado, Denver
laura.argys@ucdenver.edu